Application Responses for Spring 2026 Batch

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APPLICATION OVERVIEW

This document contains comprehensive responses to Y Combinator application questions for Control AI's Control product. The responses are crafted based on thorough analysis of the product, market, competitive landscape, and founder background.

COMPANY DESCRIPTION

Q: Describe what your company does in 50 characters or less.

A: A universal AI driver for your desktop

Q: What is your company going to make?

A: Control is a universal AI agent that operates any desktop application or system-level setting exactly like a human would. It uses computer vision to 'see' pixels and graphical interfaces (GUIs), allowing users to execute complex multi-app workflows—like professional 3D rendering in Blender or automated file management—using only natural language voice or text commands.

How It Works:

- **Universal UI Logic**: Instead of relying on brittle APIs or 'plugins,' Control parses screen pixels to identify buttons, sliders, and menus in real-time. This allows it to drive any software, from specialized tools like AutoCAD to general system settings.
- **Hybrid Action Engine**: We utilize a local execution engine for 0ms latency in mouse/keyboard actions, paired with high-reasoning Cloud APIs for visual understanding.
- **Zero-Knowledge Mastery**: We are removing the 'Software Mastery' barrier. A beginner can perform expert-level tasks in complex software simply by describing their intent (e.g., 'Make this 3D cube look like brushed aluminum and render it').
- **Cross-App Automation**: Users can chain actions together that the OS currently cannot, such as: 'Every Friday, find all my new design exports and organize them into a dated folder on my cloud drive.'

PROGRESS

Q: How far along are you?

A: We launched a private alpha 3 weeks ago. Currently, 5 beta testers are using Control to automate file exports and system-level organization. We have achieved 80% accuracy in UI element identification across Adobe Premiere and AutoCAD. We are currently adding 'Action Libraries' to allow users to save and share their custom workflows.

Q: How long have each of you been working on this?

A: I (Okorie Greatness, Founder) have been building the core software since late 2024 (originally as Aura Assistant, now Control). I have been working on this full-time, dedicating 50+ hours weekly to development and growth. My co-founder (planned CMO/COO) provides consulting expertise on consumer utility and user experience, prepared to transition to 100% full-time immediately upon acceptance into YC or successful funding.

Q: What tech stack are you using?

A: We leverage Cursor and Claude Code as our primary IDEs to accelerate development. These tools allow us to 'vibe-code' boilerplate while focusing our human engineering time on the complex coordinate-mapping and vision-latency challenges. We also use Aider for heavy multi-file refactors and Langfuse for observability to trace and debug the agent's decision-making loops in real-time.

IDEA AND MARKET

Q: Why did you pick this idea to work on?

A: I picked this idea because I lived the frustration of the 'Software Mastery' barrier. I've always wanted to be a 3D animator, but every time I opened Blender, I was met with thousands of buttons and endless hours of YouTube tutorials. I found that my work rarely matched the tutorial because I was fighting the interface instead of focusing on the art. I realized that millions of people have their creativity 'killed' by complex UIs. I'm building Control to be the bridge that lets anyone—including my younger self—go from an idea to a finished render without having to become a software expert first.

I am obsessed with the gap between human intent and software execution. We have reached a point where AI can reason better than most humans, yet we still spend 40% of our workday performing 'digital manual labor'—clicking through nested menus and managing file systems. I realized that the future of computing isn't a better UI; it's an invisible 'driver' that makes the UI irrelevant.

Q: Who are your competitors? What do you understand that they don't?

A:

Competitor Categories:

- **Big Tech (OS-Level Agents)**: Microsoft Recall/Copilot and Apple Intelligence. These are built into the OS but are often restricted by 'walled gardens' (e.g., Microsoft works best only with Office 365).
- **Browser/Cloud Agents**: OpenAI Operator and Anthropic's 'Computer Use.' These are powerful but rely heavily on the cloud, leading to latency and privacy concerns for professional work.
- **Open Source Agents**: OpenClaw and Simular. OpenClaw is a significant competitor; it's a framework that lets developers build agents. It's highly flexible but requires significant technical setup and lacks a polished, user-ready interface for non-developers.
- **Legacy RPA**: UiPath or Automation Anywhere. These are expensive, brittle, and require 'if-this-then-that' programming rather than natural language.

Our Key Insight:

What we understand that competitors don't is that power users don't want a 'walled garden' assistant; they want a scriptable, high-agency tool that bridges the gap between different apps and local workflows. While they focus on broad, safe consumer features, we are winning the high-utility automation niche by moving faster and allowing for deeper system integration.

Control is being built to be the cross-platform tissue that works everywhere. Our 'alliance' is with the user's workflow, not the OS provider. Competitors focus on 'general' tasks like booking flights or summarizing emails. We understand that the real value is in abstracting complex software interfaces. Our insight is that people don't want an 'assistant' to talk to; they want a 'driver' for their professional tools.

Q: How will you make money? How much could you make?

A:

Business Model:

We will use a tiered subscription model with a usage-based credit system for high-reasoning tasks:

- **Freemium/Entry Tier ($10-20/month)**: For 'Casual' users or beginners. Desktop agent and basic Action Credits for simple tasks.
- **Professional Tier ($50-60/month)**: For full-time creatives and engineers. Unlimited local actions and high volume of cloud-reasoning credits.
- **Enterprise/Teams ($150+ per seat)**: For studios or architecture firms. Workflow Libraries and enhanced security/privacy controls.
- **Usage-Based Upsell**: Users can buy additional Action Credits for $5-10 when needed.

Revenue Potential:

Our initial 'wedge' is the 30M+ professional 3D, CAD, and creative users. Beyond professionals, there are over 1 billion knowledge workers currently 'locked out' of powerful tools. By capturing just 1% of the global professional workforce at an average of $30/month, we reach $3.6 Billion in Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR). As we expand from specialized creative tools to general system-wide automation, we aim to capture a significant portion of the $920B+ global software market (2026 estimate).

Cost Advantage:

Since we are 'Local-First,' our infrastructure costs are significantly lower than cloud-only competitors. The user provides the 'compute' (their own PC) for the interface, while our API costs are only triggered during active 'Act' sessions.

LOCATION

Q: Where do you live now, and where would the company be based after YC?

A: Lagos, Nigeria / San Francisco & Los Angeles, USA

Q: Explain your decision regarding location.

A: For an AI startup like Control, San Francisco is the undisputed global capital. Being in the immediate vicinity of engineers from OpenAI, Anthropic, and other YC AI founders provides a massive technical advantage for our 'Computer Use' architecture. Furthermore, staying in SF during and immediately after the batch enables faster hiring of top-tier engineering talent and provides easier access to the highest concentration of follow-on venture capital.

After our initial scale in SF, we plan to establish a presence in Los Angeles. Our primary early adopters—professional 3D animation, VFX, and architectural studios—are concentrated in LA. This proximity will allow us to conduct tight, in-person feedback loops with our most demanding users, ensuring Control becomes the essential 'operating layer' for the creative and engineering industries.

Y COMBINATOR SPECIFIC

Q: What convinced you to apply to Y Combinator?

A: We are applying because 2026 is the 'Agentic Leap' year, and we need to move at YC-speed to define the standard for system-level AI control. We've built the technical foundation for an agent that 'sees' and 'acts' locally, but scaling this into a universal interface requires the high-intensity environment that only YC provides. We are specifically drawn to the mentorship of partners who have navigated massive platform shifts and the opportunity to be at the epicenter of the AI community in San Francisco as we build the 'Action Layer' for the desktop.

We've tracked the success of recent YC AI companies and realized that the 'SF-based, high-intensity batch' is the most efficient way to solve the technical latency and distribution hurdles we face. We're applying now because the 'computer use' frontier is moving fast, and we want the network effects of the YC alumni base to help us capture the professional creative market before the legacy incumbents do.

Q: How did you hear about Y Combinator?

A: I first came across Y Combinator while researching the fundamentals of starting a company. Among the various accelerators and firms I looked at, YC stood out specifically because of the partners. I recognized that the advice wasn't coming from career investors, but from operators who had actually built and scaled technical products. Seeing their track record with companies that defined new categories convinced me that YC was the right place to build a high-stakes platform like Control.

FOUNDER PROFILE

Q: Walk us through your thinking around balancing your startup, school, and other obligations.

A: I treat my startup as my full-time career and school as a background process. I have already shifted my academic load to the absolute minimum required to remain enrolled, freeing up 50+ hours a week for Control. I don't view myself as a student building a project; I am a founder who happens to be in a classroom. When a conflict arises between a lecture and a user interview, the user interview wins every time. I've built a disciplined operating rhythm where my peak cognitive hours are reserved for shipping code, regardless of my class schedule.

Q: Please tell us about a time you most successfully hacked some (non-computer) system to your advantage.

A: A friend of mine and I wanted to launch a hair product business with zero capital, so we engineered a high-velocity drop-shipping arbitrage system within our university. We identified that students wanted Temu-priced products but weren't willing to navigate the 7-14 day shipping uncertainty. We analyzed historical data from the 'Speedaf' dispatch service specifically and realized we could consistently hit a <7-day delivery window. We weaponized this data by offering a '7-7-70' guarantee: If the product didn't arrive by 7 PM on the 7th day, the customer received a 70% refund plus the product. This 'gamified' trust allowed us to charge a significant premium over the base Temu price.

Also, in order to bypass the Bells Entrepreneurship Committee (BEC)—a slow-moving regulatory body in Bells University that required lengthy referrals for new businesses—we strategically avoided registering as a 'business.' Instead, we framed our operation as a 'Personal Procurement Service.' By legally reclassifying our activity, we operated at scale without the administrative delays or fees that slowed down our competitors.

Q: Please tell us in one or two sentences about the most impressive thing other than this startup that you have built or achieved.

A: As a freshman studying Computer Science at Bells University, I built 'Bells Attend' from the ground up—a geofenced smart attendance system that replaced my university's paper-based records to prevent proxy signing. Despite being in a non-technical group, I solo-engineered the entire full-stack application, implementing location-based validation to ensure students could only check in within a specific radius of the lecturer.

PREVIOUS PROJECTS

- **BellsAttend+**: The geofenced attendance system using a 'broadcast' model where students nearby join a teacher's session. Demo: bellsattend.vercel.app | Code: github.com/Greatness0123/bells_attend
- **Index**: A software discovery tool/shopping assistant that evaluates tools based on cost, efficiency, and quality. Demo: index-tools.vercel.app | Code: github.com/Greatness0123/index
- **Aura AI**: A ChatGPT-inspired companion with personality settings and integration capabilities. Demo: auraaiweb.vercel.app | Code: github.com/Greatness0123/auraai

INTERVIEW PREPARATION

The following questions may arise during the YC interview process:

Question	Key Points to Address
What makes you the best team for this software?	Deep technical expertise, lived experience with problem, full-time commitment, complementar
What does your application do in one liner?	Universal AI driver for desktop - natural language to computer actions
Who are your target audience?	Professional creatives (initial), knowledge workers (expansion), enterprises (growth)
What is your marketing strategy?	Community building, content marketing, partnerships with creative studios, YC network
What is your business model?	Tiered SaaS subscriptions with usage-based pricing, enterprise licensing
What do you have planned for the future?	Visual workflow editor, mobile companion, API/SDK, industry modules
What is the problem statement?	Software mastery barrier prevents billions from using powerful tools effectively
What makes this an idea giants can't reach?	Cross-platform focus, local-first architecture, user-workflow alliance, faster execution

CONCLUSION

Control AI's Control represents a paradigm shift in human-computer interaction. With strong technical foundations, clear market opportunity, and a founder with deep commitment and relevant experience, Control is positioned to define the 'Action Layer' for desktop computing. Participation in Y Combinator's Spring 2026 batch would provide the acceleration, mentorship, and network necessary to capture this opportunity before incumbent competitors.